



Shared rhythm: India's Simran Sharma and her guide Umar Saifi run in perfect harmony during the T12 women's 200m at the World Para Athletics Championships. Bound by a slender tether but powered by deep trust, the pair claimed Simran's second medal of the meet. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

When running becomes a lesson in faith

Two runners, one rhythm, and the delicate art of moving in step **when one must lead and the other must believe.**

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As she crossed the finish line of the women's 200m T12 race at the Para Athletics World Championships, Simran Sharma celebrated her second medal of the competition. Earlier, she had won gold in the 100m of the same category. Running right beside her was her guide, Umar Saifi.

Though they had crossed the line together, Saifi knew his job was done.

He released the tether that bound him to Simran's hand, draped the Indian tricolour around her shoulders, and stepped back to let her soak in the moment. Simran held on to his arm as he guided her to the mixed zone, where reporters awaited. There, Saifi again stood quietly behind her while Simran — with a gold and a silver, the best haul by any Indian athlete at the Championships — faced the media.

It's always Simran who insists on bringing Saifi forward, eager to talk about their pairing.

Athletes in the T11 category (completely blind) and the T12 category (those whose visual field is restricted to about ten degrees or who can recognise a hand from less than two metres) routinely need a guide to run alongside them.

Simran and Saifi must be perfectly synchronised. They run in step, Saifi